NkxGates

(0:03 - 29:50)

Can you sleep well if you drink coffee so late at night? It might delay my going to sleep a little bit, but it'll keep me energized. So I have a long flight so I get The sleep is always complicated You're always in a hurry when you're in India. It's so much nicer to spend time with you when you're not in India.

Why is that? Well, I'll organize some of my trips where I take time off here You know next year we're talking about that I'll go up to Assam and they tell me that's pretty nice So hopefully I'll schedule a couple days for just pure relaxation But when I'm working, you know, it's it's great to see there's so many new innovators here We did manage to pack the schedule, you know, there's a lot of ministries that we have partnerships with I think I saw more ministers this time than ever before but it was they were all great meetings It's been a fun trip. We did a thing with Saatchi and I guess it's your production company or something that helped put together a very Creative thing. So you played cricket first time? Well, we we were on a tennis court and so we were hitting balls with the cricket back and the tennis We were kind of making fun of the two different sports So that that that was relaxing.

Yeah So we met recently in Switzerland and I asked you many things off-camera So I spent the last week reading source code. Oh, thanks. Yeah, it took me a long time I read much slower than you I presume it took me 14-15 hours.

So my time in the car on my flight In all my travel and before going to bed has been source code. So I know more about you now than I have ever fantastic so a Lot of what is in the book Bill? It's a great book I would recommend everybody read it but a lot what is in the book is also something I might expect of Bill Gates like my childhood was very different in the sense that when you used to Sneak out of home when your parents went to bed you went to a computer lab to bed Right, yes, that was I I was very lucky. I got to use computers a lot even in high school.

So what isn't in the book? you know the book I I feel like I you know was pretty frank about You know the challenges my parents felt raising me and you know how My Originally, I was not a very good student, you know, I at least I wasn't getting good grades and then I eventually it bugged me that People thought maybe I wasn't that smart. So I just said, okay, I guess I should get good grades You know, I got in trouble at Harvard when I was doing first using the computer and but you got you got into trouble almost for using the computer without the requisite permission from the Administrator, but that's not really trouble, you know, I was at the time it felt like it might be you know, because they They were acting pretty tough But you know, I'm not somebody who had a traumatic childhood that explains my You know, whatever energy or ambition I have I had a great childhood, you know, I had some Conflict with my mother where she would try to get me to you know Fit what she wanted and you know in a sense she succeeded in in making me want to

exceed even her expectations, so there's some energy that I got, you know from trying to You know get my freedom or in impress her But I'd say the simple story is that it You know, it's almost ideal I wish everybody had the stability and my dad was really In terms of his values, you know, he'd grown up in a very poor household. His father had only gone to sixth grade and yet He was very sophisticated always calm about everything.

It's nice having parents who are calm So I rightly or wrongly have made this presumption of late That very successful very many successful entrepreneurs Do not necessarily come from well-rounded families When I read the book I could I could see that your mom your mother was projecting Kennedy's almost the idealistic family. She was in charity. Your dad was in law Also very interestingly you speak about Your mom a lot when you're younger Your dad shows up much later in life at least in the writing and your sisters Even after that is that how? You felt their importance at different points in your life It was your mom when you were a kid your dad when you were significantly older Well, my dad Worked very long hours, so he would leave even before We had breakfast most mornings.

He had off to work When he came home, that was when we had dinner My parents were out Socializing in ways that were helpful to my dad's career three or four nights a week. And so my dad Until later was Wasn't interacting with me that much. I mean he would I'm sure he would talk to my mom about what was going on but you know The fact that he set a good example influenced me and You know the values that he had but no my my mom was the the key Relationship my sisters.

I could have talked more about them. You know, I have one sister who's a bit older and The other one's nine years behind me. So when I'm a senior, you know, which is the last time I'm at the house You know, she's a third grader so we had a fun relationship but not You know more than just playful Until we're both adults So would I be wrong in my presumption that Success in the capitalistic world of today is somehow bred By one form of adversity or another in childhood.

Well, I think if you look at the Steve Jobs story, you know, he's adopted You know his parents Kept his sister. They didn't keep him. And so he ends up with a pretty negative view towards his his fault his biological father you know Elon Musk had a fairly Complicated father, you know who would was apparently very tough on him.

So often when you see people who are You know high achievers. There's some You know something they're trying to prove in my case. You really don't have that.

I mean the only Negative thing that happens to me in my childhood is one of my friends Kent Evans Died when I was 16 and he was 17, but you know, I was already You know my energy and ambition You know had already been set so I don't you know wouldn't say that was connected So it is I think some people are surprised You know, where did I get? this desire in my 20s to be You know compared to everybody else who was starting software companies I mean by my standards

they were quite lazy Also having known you a little bit and having read the book now This one quality that you have where you're able to put your head down Focus and cram many hours of work at one go or Be Not cognizant to the things happening in the world around you but focused on one thing Where does that come from? I know in the last part of your book you spoke about how today you might be diagnosed as autistic and Is it that or is that is it some kind of drive which is coming from somewhere else? I think there's a strong genetic component to that ability to focus You know, particularly as people get older Their willingness to be very confused and just live with their confusion, you know And and until they really figure it out They almost, you know, give yourself a hard time and you know, think about why can't I understand this? You know, I think that's that's something I was lucky from nature, you know My My parents didn't push me To be that way and it was there, you know pretty early on, you know, even the thing where it Was fascinating to me that my grandmother was so much better at cards than I was and I had to think a long time to figure out. Okay. She is running a State machine.

She is remembering every card that goes by and if you remember every card that goes by okay, there is An impact on all these different card games because we played a lot of different games And she would never you know, kind of give it away. She sort of forced me to to think it through on My own so that's an early sign that yeah, I I can go off and kind of ignore What's going on and you know, I'm very lucky Even at you know this age if somebody hands me a a new book about something now, you know Shut the door and four hours later. Hopefully I've I've been able to get through it Somebody really smart was telling me that to be a hero You either need to be awe-inspiring or relatable Do you think Silicon Valley or the tech moguls in the u.s? are Using vulnerability to transition from Awe-inspiring But in a condense this might sound a little condescending not that I mean it Robot-like behavior to more human-like personas like if you look at Mark Zuckerberg with him, you know Wearing his new clothes his chain his watch Is the world going that way where you don't want that clean-cut awe-inspiring hero anymore You need something more relatable and people are showcasing their vulnerabilities to meet that end Well, I don't think you know, I think Mark sincerely likes Extreme sports and You know, he really does You know engage in that I never found that All that attractive.

So I think he's being genuine You know, he's a great family person You know, he's he's he's still pretty young he just turned 40 which nowadays I have to consider that a young person, you know, I I think the people who get to know you are the people either your family or the people who work with you very closely and You know take for example Steve Jobs he was tough on himself He did have the most unbelievable Sense of people just in an intuitive way and a good design You know, so his skills and mine don't even overlap that much he was not an engineer and I'm not a design person I wish I was a design person and I don't know if he wished he was an engineer. He was good at picking engineers and so Apple You know really distinguished itself, but it wasn't it wasn't an act He was a natural I had to learn how to give speeches and All that and you know, even at my best I'm not As much of a speech giver as he was So he's pretty singular I would say You know, maybe Elon in his in a different ways is kind of singular I think of Mark is a

pretty normal person actually You know, he's got a great wife You know very serious about his kids You just said that Steve Jobs was maybe too hard on himself. Are you hard on yourself though? Why are you running around so much meeting all the politicians and everything? No, I think if you want to you know, work hard and not fool yourself.

You better be pretty hard on yourself and Steve was Tough on himself and it makes you at first Maybe not a very good manager because you tend to manage people like you manage yourself where you're just so tough on them and you know for me that meant that in my early days, I could get a lot out of people who were like me and You know, so I probably missed some people who were very different than me that could have been, you know part of the company We were fairly homogeneous very engineering oriented group and it took a while before I realized Okay, somebody who's a good sales person or a good manager, you know may not be Good at the way. I think of IQ IQ is much more varied talent is more varied than I realized You know, I sort of thought well if you can do math you can do anything and if you can't do math Then you can't do anything. That's how simple That initial thing was so I was you know, it took me a lot of time To develop as a manager, you know, I think as I moved to the foundation It was very important that I blend in people who like to work in the field in Africa with great scientists with great people who work with government so I You know, I was able to take the mistakes I made and learnings from Microsoft and Bring that to the foundation but You know the why I I chose To work so hard in my 20s.

I mean, I I love the work. I think 20s I get bill The question is today Oh today. Yeah.

Well, it's optional It is a lot of fun. I get to work with Smart people I'm learning all the time I You know, I get to travel the world the world this haven't you traveled the world already, you know in my Microsoft work I went to Africa. I went to South Africa once in Egypt once and so basically, you know They don't buy much software in Africa.

They buy some but it's not Now, you know Africa's, you know huge In in what I do, so I've been exposed to different parts You know, I remember with one of the top Microsoft people When I was in India, we were flying Over Bangalore. Yeah, and and he was saying oh, there's no slums in Bangalore Then we flew over an area and I was pointing down and I said, yeah, I don't think so And he was like god, I've never seen that there are lesser slums in Bangalore than anywhere in it. Okay, I think I'm and you know, so the You know the glimpse of the world you get as the CEO of Microsoft is not quite the same as You know being co-chair of the Gates Foundation I mean, you know, we make lots of jokes about you know, when I came to India for a long time I was meeting with sex workers because our original work here called Abaham was about Avoiding an HIV epidemic in the country and the key to that was going to be make sure that that it didn't get into the sex worker community because Then it would have spread to the general population.

And so, you know Ashok Alexander and our our team people we created communities of sex workers where In the community their lives were improved enough that they would listen to the

idea of you know, please Use condoms and and you know, so I certainly got to meet a lot of people that I'd never met at Microsoft Yeah, if I were to ask you to extrapolate with no filters Since you know more about AI than I will ever In the world of tomorrow ten years from now from a very capitalistic lens Is a huge population a boon or a bane? The let's say 20 years from now AI will have changed things enough that You know that just this pure capitalistic framework probably won't explain much because as AIs both as sort of white-collar type Work and as blue-collar workers the robots will get good hands and are able to do the physical things that that humans do say working in a factory or construction or you know going cleaning a Hotel room which you know the hands have to be awfully good to do those things will will achieve that and We'll have a lot of Making the goods and services Which is always we've always had a shortage a shortage of doctors and teachers of people to work in the factories Those shortages won't exist. And so it's it's a pretty profound change that will free up a lot of time, you know, you can retire early you can work shorter work weeks and It's gonna require almost a Philosophical rethink about okay. How should time be spent because we don't need it to make enough food and make enough widgets and You know do enough medical diagnosis.

We will have created You know free intelligence, you know in my day. It was about computing was expensive. It became free now.

It's Intelligence like a doctor's intelligence is scarce, you know India Has more doctors than Africa, but still not nearly as many as it should but AI Will come in and provide, you know medical IQ and there won't be a shortage That's and it's hard for those of us you know in my case spending almost 70 years in a year in a world of shortage to even adjust my mind because You know, what are markets about markets are about scarce Resources and a price is okay. You know, you get the employee because you're willing to pay pay them more and So, you know I find myself trying to understand that future world but It hasn't come into focus for me and I I enjoy engaging experts about okay What does the economy look like and and how will we choose to use the the freedom? That will come and you know, even if I'm wrong say it's 30 years. That's not a very long time.

I mean my Kids and certainly my grandkids a lot of their life will be in that that very changed world This economist John Maynard Keynes. I think the American model is largely Keynesian Where they print money the antithesis to Hayek almost he said this many decades ago that the real question is What will the world do if one did not have to work if you had to like extrapolate one statement in 30 40 50 how many ever years? What do we do if we don't have to work? I don't have to work and so I choose to work because Yeah, because it's fun. You know, I take more vacation than I did when I was young, but it's still, you know, basically full full-time work and But it's If you had that your whole life It's different than being able to retire early I mean at least we you know have a period of working and then you know, if you said everybody could retire it at 40 You know how radical is that Maybe not not that radical But if you said you never need to work at least to me I've what you know that that is so Yeah, different.

I think another very interesting question is if we all don't work. Do we get the same? Humans inherently are competitive with their peer groups. I think So if I don't work say we are born tomorrow me you him him We all don't work, but we are bestow bestowed upon with the same Resources and same social position will that work for us? Well, no I Your your points a good one.

We want to differentiate you know, whether it's for our own ego or to be attractive or It's so weird. We are so adapted to this world of shortage That you know, maybe You know will create competitions and you know creativity or you know Maybe we'll take some part of human activity. I mean in extreme cases We're not gonna have robots play cricket, you know, that's boring Reserve that just for the humans, even if the robots could be, you know, way way better Yeah, that's that's not interesting.

And so what activities might a country say no, we're reserving this, you know nurses are going to be humans or You know psychiatrists You know are we're gonna, you know decide that that and so we might artificially Ignore the fact that the the machines can Can substitute for some of that It's it'll really, you know get down to the core of human instinct. Yeah, we will figure out a hierarchy It may not be the current one, but another way to segregate ourselves Yes, the idea of you know, pure communism that everybody, you know is is totally the same. That's a pretty unnatural behavior for for humans Needs a lot of trust of a model like that to work and I think as the group gets larger trust is often not there inherently You've been the richest man in the world for a very long time, Bill You've probably had access to everybody for a long long time I'm talking world leaders philosophers people at the cutting edge of everything What do you know that I don't like one thing? What have you learned? By having lived in your shoes, you know, I know a lot about science You know, I've seen a lot of successful people And you know learned the habits That they have I do think you develop Instincts about you know who to hire who to partner with just from mistakes and You know pattern matching, you know, and I've been super lucky people like Warren Buffett who comes from a very different Expertise than mine, you know, he and I have bonded over You know sharing ideas and kind of common view of how things work in the world and he is On a lot of things just his wisdom is has been a huge help to me Not so much about business but more about life Well, it's certainly, you know, the decisions you make about your personal life probably affect your happiness You know, I know super successful people who aren't that happy and You know didn't apply their Weren't able to map their incredible intelligence on to Having a great Relationship with their kids or you know their extended family, so It is human capabilities is very strange that you can't You know like my friend Paul Allen You know, he was wonderful he was key to the success of Microsoft but he actually didn't end up enjoying himself You know, he felt like maybe people were gonna take advantage of him and that that's you know, this guy Who had everything and yet it didn't didn't really create? Comfort or The happiness he he deserved when people ask me what drives me I mean, I'm a Much less wise experienced all of those things but in my own little bubble some people do ask me what drives me.

I Used to stupidly say Whenever someone asked me how you got lucky or how you did well in life

my Go-to answer used to be luck, which was never the truth because I think we all have All humans I think have a inflated sense of self Subconsciously deep deep down like if I were to put hundred people in a room and ask how many of you are smarter than Majority I would presume 99% or 89% I don't say yes, maybe that's a slight exaggeration, but I think the point holds But when I were to think about what drives me deeply In the beginning, I think it was just money. I feel like I didn't have money I wanted money because my conditioning my years growing up looking at the people around me with money They looked happy. I think money transitioned into Relatively more power jealousy insecurity seeking validation different drivers for different parts of my life and Today I'm flirting with this notion like I'm part of your pledge and I spend time with you every year on the offside and I don't know if you remember but last year I was asking these same questions because I genuinely do not know the answer At times I might feel Altruistic at times I might feel like there is no point to more But at other times I will go back to the very relative Nature of things and competition kicks in and I want more What I wanted from our conversation today, it's more a question for me than it is for other people is this concept of Motivational pluralism in a way where I can be motivated by different things at different points of time.

(29:51 - 41:52)

I might also want to make money, but I might also want to give away money I think you're at the forefront of that. Would you like to like share your thoughts in that? How does it make sense to want to make money while you want to also give away money? Well, even giving away money can be Very egotistical. There's certainly ego involved.

I mean, you know when I say I want to eradicate polio it's a mix of you know, my ego wants that success on my resume and you know some degree of Excitement and admiration will come from that, you know It's partly that of all the things the Gates Foundation does the one that Warren Buffett You know, that's black and white to him because he grew up when there was a lot of polio. You know, he'll often ask me Okay, how's polio going? And so I'd love to say to him, which it's a race, you know, Warren's 94 and we'll live forever I'd love someday to say to my friend. Hey, you know polio's done And he that would make him feel even better about the resources he Gave to the Gates Foundation and you know, and I also do when I see kids who are paralyzed with polio I think you know, that's a bad thing.

So it's it's a whole range of Ego, you know that validating my friend's generosity and and you know general moral excellence and You know Ted Turner used to say that The Forbes list was which ranks yeah Well was a bad thing because people would hesitate to give away money because they wouldn't Achieve some rank on the on the Forbes list. Mm-hmm, and I think he had a valid point there You can never do anything. That's totally pure.

Mm-hmm Because if it's really deeply moral Then a little bit you think oh people will praise that and so, you know, is it ego or not? You know in the end the the work, you know like the work we've done with vaccines You know whether that was my ego or not it you know, it's a it's a real

thing that happened You know, I remember when I left Microsoft thinking gosh if it gets messed up It's gonna screw up my mind Should I go back or not go back and I'm so lucky that you know Steve did a very good job and now Satya is doing a Very good job, so I haven't had to worry about that. It also helped that it made my Microsoft stock Valuable enough that even though I've given away a Lot, you know, I still You know, I'm not nearly as as rich as as some but I'm in the top 20 and that's great. You know, I'm over the next 20 years all I'll be able to give a lot away But even that's not doesn't get you out of the why they why do I I do it? I find like I don't feel altruistic.

I feel like Even when you quietly do something good in terms of giving away money, which does something for someone It is almost more intoxicating than a capitalistic pursuit which is making money so they're both highs now If I don't know which high is more appealing to me at which point of time How do you switch between the two? You know philanthropy isn't quite as competitive I mean, you know creating a company, you know that It's pretty stark because You know, there might be some category That if you get scale, you know, the other people just fall by the wayside, you know, it's not like You end up splitting it. It's you know when we did Microsoft Office there were quite a few companies that were in that space that literally we they went away and You know, we we competed with Google over the mobile phone operating system and we fell behind and you know today nobody remembers there was a Windows mobile thing. It's just Android for non Apple phones.

It's basically all Android that was a winner-take-all thing and So when you get into one of those you actually activate not only ego, but a little bit of fear and you know certainly in my 20s and 30s I That was part of it, which is Wow You know, I think I'm pretty good at this but you know, have I just made that up? Am I really good? Will I be revealed that I you know, didn't do a good job? I've gotten past that now. I don't think I'm motivated by a Fear but it's it was fascinating to me that you know, I would when we would go on company retreats from Microsoft It would bother me that the other leaders didn't think our Survival was at risk. I was always coming up with no we have to worry about this we have to worry about this because it was my whole life and I have to say leaving And moving to the foundation made my life a little bit more sane because I wasn't always Conjuring up the okay.

It could you know all you know completely blow up and so You know, I engaged every emotion to drive myself in my 20s So I was having lunch with my team today Bill. They're all like a bunch of them are 21, 23, 24 And even at 38, I'm so disconnected with how they think they're their version of reality in a way Whenever we've whenever I've seen you for a meal lunch dinner beat whatever there's always wine They say that people are like the vintage of wine from the year that they're born in So let's say you were born in year X and you're from that vintage What assumption of the world today or the youth of the world today? Do you think that you have? which is not fully true and How do you look at the world today, but it doesn't resonate for the youth of today, you know, it's nice To have your kids give you a hard time. Did you get a little bit of? Realizing Wow There's a different way of looking at things, you know Some things like I'm very email centric which my

my youngest daughter thinks is so laughable And you know when she sends me a text I don't respond in five minutes and she's like what's wrong with you? Dad, I'm not gonna change it.

I'm sorry. I'm kind of stuck in my email centric ways You know, so I'll I'll just have to live with that You know, I You know, I was very lucky the insight that computing would become free You know for my generation there were very few people who saw that and so I you know, I had an advantage because that implied a lot of things that that Microsoft could get out and in front of now this this current revolution in a way everybody kind of sees it coming It's almost too wild to be true. But yes, it's it's not like there's only a small community Sees AI coming and I'm not sure do the young people Have an anticipation of what it's going to be like better I Hope so because they're the ones who you know be in charge and and and have to deal with it I think it's a rate of change That's greater than most most periods of history You know when we made in the US, you know when we went from 50% farmers to 2% farmers If you could still farm your whole generation It was your children's that stopped being farmers, you know, because it happened over 60 year period we go from a very high percentage down here You know even within a generation You know certain skills are aren't going to be as as needed so I think that's a pretty wild thing To be to be changing things, you know, and you it's nice to surround your people yourself with with young people And have their insights, of course your customers aren't all young so you have to You know stay in touch with what they're thinking as well If I may pay you a compliment bill after having spent time with you for a few years I Feel like you care Lesser today about what people think about you and that is making you Increasingly more appealing to the youth And I think that comes out in your book as well.

No, I mean if anybody can afford to not You know think about you know, there are people who like me more than there should there people who hate me Well, they should I mean it's you know a wild Mix, you know, including crazy conspiracies And so I do think with age Your ego needs go down a bit Your desire to help others succeed versus just yourself You know, you get a little bit they call it general more generative and sharing advice having kids helps with that a lot and You know, so I should have the luxury Yeah worrying about these things, you know, ironically, I think that is the definition of cool for the youth today not getting Thank You bill thank you for doing this and I think I'm seeing you know great to see you and yeah Yes, you're coming to the giving. Yeah. Yeah.

Oh perfect No, it's always fun to see you there Thanks You